

Service Provider Promising Practice

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TOPIC:
Working with Staff

Addressing Staffing Shortages: Lessons from Advance Opportunities

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BACKGROUND

Advance Opportunities is an employment provider in Minnesota. Advance provides a full range of services, including vocational rehabilitation (VR) and waiver-funded programs, individualized in-home services, and day supports as a wraparound service. Before the COVID-19 public health emergency (PHE), Advance served around 100 people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) and had 38 employees. After the pandemic, Advance resumed operations but could not bring back the entire team. Currently, the provider serves 54 people with IDD and has about 20 employees. Advance has 42 people with IDD who would like to receive either wraparound or employment services, but Advance does not have enough staff to provide services to more people.

IMPLEMENTATION

Like other employment service providers, Advance faces challenges with staff recruitment and retention, which were worsened by the COVID-19 PHE. While Advance has not returned to the full number of staff they had prior to the PHE, they have seen progress due to several new strategies. Advance has implemented a multi-faceted approach to addressing staff recruitment and retention, which are detailed in this Promising Practice.

A dedicated human resources department

Advance found that they needed to have a full-time human resource (HR) staff dedicated to recruitment and retention. To make this possible Advance merged with PHASE Industries, which

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enabled them to share HR personnel. Having full-time staff dedicated to this role helped Advance revamp and diversify their recruitment and retention strategies, some of which we outline in this Promising Practice.

Hiring for potential, not just experience

Advance found that it was difficult to find people in their local community who were looking for a job and who had the training and experience to provide employment services. They changed their process to focus on recruiting new employees based on their skills, aptitude, and passion to work with people with IDD. These staff are hired as generalists and begin their employment with a focus on community enrichment and engagement services. Advance then identifies employees from the generalists pool and prepares them to become employment specialists. This approach creates an organizational pipeline for employment staff.

Deliberate orientation and mentorship for new hires

Advance's HR Generalist introduced a structured two-week orientation to welcome all new employees into the organization in a supported way. In the first week, the HR Generalist supports the new employee with required trainings and becoming familiar with the day-to-day routine of their position. During



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the second week, the employee connects with their direct supervisor over a breakfast meeting and the HR Generalist turns training responsibilities over to the supervisor.

While the initial orientation is crucial for new employees in their first weeks, Advance recognizes it can take 6–12 months for employees to fully learn the job and feel comfortable. To bridge that gap, Advance introduced a formal mentorship system that pairs new hires with a mentor. The mentorship system ensures that new employees have someone approachable and available for all their questions who can support them as they learn their jobs and integrate in the organization. This formal mentorship continues until the employee reaches a point where they are comfortable with the role and can become a mentor themselves.

Improving organizational culture

Advance implemented cultural changes to foster a friendly work environment where people felt connected and motivated to go to work. As the Chief Operating Officer shared, “we’re focusing on creating a familial atmosphere where everybody has somebody they look forward to seeing at work.” Advance achieved a sense of community through opportunities like having the office manager bring lunch for new employees’ first day of orientation and having a few staff members join them so they can engage with colleagues.

Another cultural and philosophical change that improved Advance’s culture was focusing on the dignity of risk. This meant helping their employees learn how to support people with IDD to have more autonomy and independence and reduce their need for constant in-person support from a staff member. This was based on the understanding that people, regardless of disabilities, must be able to make their own choices. As the Chief Operating Officer put it, “we recognize that people can make their own choices, and there’s a level of risk that has to be allowed. You can’t prevent all accidents, or all bad decisions. We have to let people be people, whether they have disabilities or not.” To

support this outcome, employees focus on supporting people with IDD to learn skills and build relationships that can increase their independence. This means ensuring that staff see their role as a supporter rather than a caregiver.

This shift allowed Advance to more effectively use the staffing resources they have and promote self-determination for people with IDD.

Process mapping to streamline workflows and establish clear roles and procedures

Advance used Patrick Lencioni’s Five Dysfunctions of a Team as a guide to evaluate any dysfunctional processes and identify the most important organizational goals. Some of the goals they identified included the needs to streamline workflows and to clearly define roles and services to make everyone’s job more straightforward. As the Chief Operating Officer put it, “the idea is that hopefully everybody’s job will be just a little bit easier when it’s all mapped out, and you don’t have to think about every single step and risk forgetting important details.” This process mapping has already led to clarity between the roles of Direct Support Professionals and Employment Support Professionals so that they can focus on the unique aspects of their roles. This allows staff providing supports around community engagement to create more meaningful connections that provide opportunities for people with IDD. It also allows staff providing employment supports to learn more about the nuances of creating beneficial connections between employers, community members, and people with IDD to create pathways to meaningful employment. The leadership anticipates that this process mapping will continue to improve workflows, role clarity, foster trust, and result in better employment opportunities and outcomes for people with IDD.

Financial incentives

Advance introduced a period of sign-on and referral bonuses, which helped improve their hiring efforts. Bonuses proved to be an effective strategy—Advance successfully hired five new employees in a short timeframe when they offered the incentives.

IMPACT

Advance experienced staff shortages that were made worse by the COVID-19 PHE. To address the staff shortages, Advance implemented a comprehensive strategy, which included:

- » establishing a dedicated HR staff member
- » changing recruitment methods
- » starting a mentorship program for new staff
- » creating a friendly work environment
- » optimizing their workflows
- » providing financial incentives

These efforts have impacted Advance's ability to recruit and retain employment staff and improve choice and independence for people with IDD. These efforts will ultimately help in reducing their waitlist.

SUGGESTIONS FOR REPLICATION

Invest in dedicated HR staff to support recruitment and retention:

It's crucial to have dedicated HR staff to support effective recruitment and retention strategies. Collaborating with another provider organization can offer a cost-effective means to establishing HR staff who can fully focus on recruitment, following up with candidates, offering sign-on and referral bonuses, and implementing various strategies to improve retention.

Implement a formal onboarding and mentorship system:

Effective orientation and onboarding is key to helping new employees understand their role expectations and smoothly transition into their jobs. It is important to offer an orientation that is structured, provides training in a supportive way, and provides connection to direct supervisors and colleagues as new employees integrate into the organization. This supportive onboarding can be complemented with mentorship between experienced staff members and new employees, providing ample time and support as new hires navigate their roles.

Create a positive workplace culture: Improving organizational culture is a central strategy for enhancing retention. Offering opportunities for employees to feel connected—such as a new hire introductory breakfast meeting with their supervisor or staff joining orientation lunches—creates a sense of community, strengthens relationships, and promotes retention. In addition, streamlining workflows and enhancing role clarity for employees can improve efficacy and trust among staff.

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